# Joaquín Paleo

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## Education

**Ph.D. in Economics**, University of California, Davis — expected 2027
**M.A. in Economics**, Universidad de la República, Uruguay — 2021
Thesis: *The Allocation of Houses within Housing Cooperatives: A Market Design Approach*
**Licenciatura en Economía** (B.A.), Universidad de la República, Uruguay — 2019

## Research Fields

Primary: Labor Economics, Economics of Education. Secondary: Applied Microeconomics.

## Job Market Paper

**Grades, Academic Performance, and Labor Market Outcomes**
with Mathías Fondo and Rodrigo Nicolau

*Abstract*: Grades open doors to scholarships, graduate programs, and jobs, but distinguishing the effect of grades from the underlying ability they measure is hard. We study this question by implementing a Regression Discontinuity Design around grade-jump cutoffs at Uruguay's main higher education institution, where a deterministic rule converts continuous course scores into coarser transcript grades. Marginally earning a higher first-semester grade raises next-semester GPA by 0.23 standard deviations. Because students observe both the score and the grade, the response reflects the transcript label rather than anything students learn about their own ability. In the labor market, monthly earnings at the first job show no detectable change. In contrast, hourly wages are 17 to 21 percent higher, while weekly hours worked are 2.2 to 2.8 hours lower. The wage premium fades quickly, but the hours reduction persists. These findings seem to be driven by within-industry changes, rather than students sorting across industries with systematically different jobs. A higher grade also raises public-sector entry by 7 percentage points, where hiring rules score GPA explicitly. Finally, among students who start working after the grade is realized, we find evidence that academic performance improves in the semesters after the first job begins, relative to students who marginally earned a lower grade, which is consistent with them working fewer hours.

## Working Papers

**Unionization and College Enrollment: Evidence from Close Union Elections**

## Work in Progress

**Information about Relative Performance and Future Academic Achievement**
with Mathías Fondo and Rodrigo Nicolau
**The Short-Run Effects of Mexican-American School Desegregation**

## Presentations

**2026:** Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting (scheduled); All-California Labor Economics Conference; UC Davis Applied Microeconomics Seminar; UC Davis Alumni Conference (Poster)
**2025:** All-California Labor Economics Conference (Poster); UC Davis internal seminars (2)

## Teaching Experience

**University of California, Davis**

*Associate Instructor (instructor of record)*

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| Industrial Organization (ECN 121A) | Spring 2027 (scheduled) |

*Teaching Assistant*

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| Intermediate Micro Theory: Consumer and Producer Theory (ECN 100A) | Su 2024, F 2024, W 2025, Sp 2025 |
| Intermediate Micro Theory: Imperfect Competition and Market Failure (ECN 100B) | W 2026 |
| Theory of Games and Strategic Behavior (ECN 122) | Su 2023, F 2023, Sp 2024 |
| Economics of Uncertainty and Information (ECN 103) | F 2022, W 2023 |
| Public Microeconomics (ECN 130) | Sp 2026 |
| Decision Making (ECN 106) | W 2024 |
| Industrial Organization (ECN 121A) | Su 2023 |
| Principles of Microeconomics (ECN 1A) | Sp 2023 |

*Reader*

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| International Economic Relations (ECN 162) | F 2026 |

## Research Experience

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| **Graduate Student Researcher**, University of California, Davis | Summer 2026 |
| **Research Fellow** (Initiation to Research Program), Universidad de la República, Montevideo | 2020 – 2021 |
| **Research Assistant**, Instituto de Economía, Universidad de la República | Jan – May 2020 |
| **Assistant**, Statistics Unit, Ministerio de Trabajo y Seguridad Social, Montevideo | 2019 |

## Awards and Fellowships

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| Department Travel Award, University of California, Davis | 2024 |
| Best Master's Thesis Award, Sociedad de Economistas del Uruguay | 2021 |
| Provost's First Year Fellowship, University of California, Davis | 2021 |
| Initiation to Research Fellowship, Universidad de la República | 2020 |

## Other Information

**Languages:** Spanish (native), English (fluent), Portuguese (intermediate)

**Software:** Stata, Python, R, LaTeX

**Citizenship:** Uruguayan and Spanish